



“Looking Into the Face of Jesus”

2 Corinthians 3:18-4:6

“But we all, with unveiled face, beholding as in a mirror the glory of the Lord, are being transformed into the same image from glory to glory, just as by the Spirit of the Lord.”

2 Corinthians 3:18

The Apostle Paul personally discipled Timothy to equip him to finish the ministry he had started; to take the truths he had learned from Paul and communicate them to the next generation. In view of his imminent death, Paul wrote a second letter to Timothy, exhorting him to be:

- **A good teacher** – don’t give up until the students have learned.
- **A good soldier** – don’t quit until the enemy is defeated.
- **A good athlete** – don’t stop running until you reach the finish line
- **A good farmer** – don’t stop sowing the gospel and reaping the harvest.

But above all this, in 2 Timothy 2:8, Paul told young Timothy, **“Remember Jesus Christ,”** for long after Paul was gone, Jesus would still be there as the model teacher, the model soldier, the model athlete, and the model farmer.

Given the spiritual apathy and doctrinal apostasy of our day, it is vitally important that every Christian knows what they believe about their eternal salvation, why they believe it, and are able to defend it.

- However, there is an even greater challenge today's Christians must accept, and that is to keep our eyes fixed on Jesus Christ, for that vision of Jesus may be all we have to sustain us through the very difficult times ahead.
- David said – ***"I have set the Lord always before me! Because He is at my right hand I shall not be moved. Therefore, my heart is glad, and my glory rejoices. You will show me the path of life; In Your presence is fullness of joy; At Your right hand are pleasures forevermore."*** From Psalm 16
- Paul said – ***"I count all things loss for the excellence of the knowledge of Christ Jesus my Lord."*** – Philippians 3:8

In 2 Corinthians 3:18-4:6, the Apostle Paul said he saw the ***"Glory of God in the face of Jesus Christ."***

- The Christians in Corinth had lost their vision of Christ. They were embracing the lies of the false teachers, abusing the Lord's Supper, and participating in the deepest forms of sexual immorality, including incest.
- However, Paul said, even in the midst of such wickedness and moral depravity, he did not "lose heart," because his vision was not upon the ministry to which he had been called, but upon the Lord Jesus who had called him.
- Up until that day on the Damascus Road, Paul considered Jesus a troublemaker, a blasphemer, a deceiver, a hindrance to the growth of Judaism, and those who followed Him should be imprisoned or executed – that was Paul's view of Christ in the flesh!
- However, once the Holy Spirit opened his eyes to see Jesus as the Messiah, Paul fixed his eyes upon that shekinah glory that had once blinded him, and it was that "unveiled vision" that sustained him through the trials and suffering of carrying out his mission.
- When the Holy Spirit opened Paul's eyes to see Jesus as the Messiah, the Savior sent from God, Paul saw the glory of God in the face of the living Lord.
- That same vision is available to all who will consistently and persistently study the Holy Scriptures, ***"For God, who said, 'Let light shine out of darkness,' has shone in our hearts to give the light of the knowledge of the glory of God in the face of Jesus Christ."*** 2 Corinthians 4:6

1. A Clarifying Look – The "fleshly" views of Christ will be no more – we will see the image of the true and living God in the face of the living Lord Jesus.

- 2 Corinthians 3:16ff, ***"Nevertheless, when one turns to the Lord, the veil is taken away. Now the Lord is the Spirit; and where the Spirit of the Lord is, there is liberty. But we all, with unveiled face, beholding as in a mirror the glory of the Lord, are being transformed into the same image from glory to glory."***
- When we see Jesus in all of His glory, we will see everything God has revealed to us about Himself; His attributes, His character, His love, His loyalty, His grace, His power, His wisdom, etc.
- In Hebrews 11, the writer documented the "Hall of Faith," those Old Testament saints who obtained a good testimony because of their extraordinary faith in God.
- However, Paul said we have an even greater vision of God than they did, for we have the privilege of having received the promise of God in sending His Son to be our Savior.

2. A Transforming Look – If our view of Jesus is for the right purpose, the Holy Spirit will transform our image into the image of Christ – not all at once, but from one stage of glory to the next, until we meet Him face to face.

- The more we seek the face of Jesus in our study of God's Holy Word, the more the Holy Spirit transforms us from one stage of glory, to another, and then another, and on and on.
- This is the purpose behind the expository preaching of the Bible.
- True preaching is not choosing a "topic" and then finding verses in the Bible to support it.
- True, expository preaching is a balanced and systematic study of:
 - The Old Testament Law and the Prophets – Jesus is predicted.
 - The Gospels – Jesus is revealed.
 - The Book of Acts – Jesus is preached.
 - The Epistles – Jesus is explained.
 - The Book of Revelation – Jesus is expected.
- In true, expository preaching, the primary concern of the preacher is to use every method possible to analyze the text, within the context of the chapter, and the book or letter in which it is written, to understand its original meaning.
- Then, and only then, should the preacher draw any applications to the hearers' lives or current circumstances.
- The phrase, "We would see Jesus" warns preachers not to misuse, or abuse the true preaching of God's Holy Word.

3. A Grateful look – When we take the time to get alone with the Lord Jesus and look full into that wonderful face, as revealed in the Holy Scriptures, not only will the things of this earth grow strangely dim, but we will be overwhelmed with gratitude for all He has done, is doing, and has promised to do, for those who believe in Him.

- When we fully understand that our salvation is a gift of God's mercy and God's grace, and not the result of anything we have or haven't done, or will or will not do, we can't help but cry out unto the Lord with thanksgiving.
- Reading about God's faithfulness in the lives of those who obeyed Him, even though their obedience resulted in sorrow and suffering, prompts us to acknowledge the many ways He has been, is being, and continues to be faithful unto us today.
- The Bible is replete with examples of God's love, God's grace, God's mercy, and God's goodness, prompting us to be thankful for His blessings in our lives.
- By meditating on the Scriptures, we can develop an attitude of gratitude that God can use to strengthen other believers as they see us expressing a joy and a peace that passes all understanding.

4. A Purifying Look – 2 Corinthians 4:2 – "We've renounced the hidden things of shame."

- If we will take the time to continuously study God's Holy Word, and remain there until we have seen the glory of God in the face of Jesus, not only will we be transformed into the image of Christ, but God will convict us to put away those

things that not only veiled our view of Him, but also veiled our witness to others.

- Those things that once, we thought, brought us fame, now, we know, are the things that bring us shame, and we renounce them.
- Even the desire for those things will be replaced by your desire to know even more about the Lord Jesus Christ.



Focus on the FOUR DOTS in the middle of the picture for about 30 seconds
Then, close your eyes and look up into a bright light!